

the fourth carriage, shattered a few windows, and caused minor damage to a few carriages. The train's speed, momentum of coaches, and the pull of the engine saved the day, for the aim had been to derail the train, causing it to plunge down an embankment. Lord and Lady Irwin had had a lucky escape.

The bombing of the Viceregal Special, or the Delhi Conspiracy Case as it was called, caused a furore and was widely condemned by nationalist leaders such as Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi. Railway sabotage and bombings were outside the purview of Civil Disobedience. This, however, was not the first time that the revolutionaries had attacked the railways as an expression of dissent. Over the decades, the railways in India had gained a large visual presence and became an easy target.

### **Colonial symbol of power**

The railway network and the trains themselves were the ultimate symbol of colonialism. "Train-wrecking" was often employed as a form of protest. One of the earliest instances was in 1866 when the people of Bhagalpur (in present-day Bihar) attempted to derail a train as a protest against increasing food prices.

The nature of these protests changed with the partition of the Bengal Presidency in 1905. Radicalized groups demonstrated their dissent by attacking the railways with strategically placed bombs on tracks, or throwing bombs at the rail carriages. In 1907, members of the revolutionary outfit "Anushilan Samiti" conducted a series of attacks on the special trains used by Sir Andrew Fraser, Bengal's lieutenant governor (1903–06). During the first attempt, on the Calcutta–Ranchi route, the dynamite exploded but did not do any damage. The second attempt failed as well. The third involved a mine with almost 3 kg of dynamite near Kharagpur, West Bengal. While the explosion did not derail the train, it did significant damage to the railway line as it blew a hole in the permanent way and bent one of the rails. The British Indian Government tried to curb this growing menace by passing the Explosive Substances Act in 1908 to stop the proliferation of explosives in the hands of dissidents and revolutionaries.